in peace time by conducting as many training and social events in their units or formations during their brief tenures of two years or less. This has resulted in combat units spending about 50 per cent of their time in peace stations out of their barracks. A feeling has crept in amongst the soldiers that they are better off in the field areas than in peace stations. This is definitely not good for morale. Hence, as the chief, I gave instructions that routine training and sports activities should be spread out over a time span of two years and, as far as possible, no unit should be out of their cantonments for more than two months in a year in peace stations.

The role of women in the armed forces has been a subject of discussion for quite some time. I have no doubt that the women would admirably complement the men and act as force multipliers in certain areas. However, at present, they are being inducted as officers in many arms and services other than combat arms like mechanized forces, infantry or artillery. Further, wherever they are able to do the mandatory command and staff assignments and qualify in career courses, there should be no bar to their elevation to higher ranks and tenure in service, akin to the men. During my tenure as the COAS, a furore took place when the vice chief made a remark that, 'the army could do without women'. His comments were blown out of proportion by some women's organizations and the media. Yet in order to defuse the situation, I advised him to clear the air and render a polite apology. This he did, the gentleman that he was, and the issue was resolved. However, the debate still continues.

The National Cadet Corps and the Sainik Schools are the feeder organizations which in recent years have provided a large proportion of the leadership in the armed forces and also in the civilian domain. A few million disciplined and patriotic young men and women have passed through the portals of these institutions over the past six decades. The NCC is a tri-service organization and has produced outstanding leaders in the fields of science, politics, public and private sector, sports, arts and culture, besides the military. It is a delight to see the radiant faces of these motivated